Curiosity Rover Sees Mystery Cliffs on Mars

From: ScienceDaily Top Technology Mined: 2026-10-23 3 min read

NASA's Curiosity **rover** has sent home a beautiful new picture of Mars. It shows strange cliffs far away that were shaped by wind.

The **rover** took six photos on August 11, early in the **Martian** morning. Scientists put them together into one wide view. The front of the picture looks bluish, and sunlight shines on the cliffs.

These cliffs are called **yardangs**. They stretch about 10 miles across Mount Sharp, a mountain about 3 miles tall. Curiosity has been climbing it since 2014.

The mountain's rock layers show that long ago, Mars had lakes and streams. But the yardang layer is a puzzle. It is a different color and its layers tilt in an odd way. NASA scientist Ashwin Vasavada said it might be ash from ancient **volcanoes**.

Curiosity should reach the cliffs in 2027. Then it can study them with its **robotic arm**.

Word Treasure

rover -- A robot car that explores another planet.

Martian -- Having to do with the planet Mars.

yardangs -- Cliffs or ridges carved by wind.

volcanoes -- Mountains that can burst out lava and ash.

robotic arm -- A machine arm that can reach out and use tools.

Background you need

Curiosity is a NASA robot that has been exploring Mars and climbing a mountain there.

Layers of rock are like pages in a history book that tell scientists what Mars was like long ago.

Break it down

WHO: NASA's Curiosity rover and scientist Ashwin Vasavada
WHAT: Took a new picture of mysterious wind-carved cliffs
WHERE: On Mount Sharp on Mars
WHY: Scientists want to learn how the strange cliffs formed

Why it matters

Exploring Mars helps us learn how planets, including Earth, can change over time.

Test what you remember

1. What did Curiosity send home?

- (A) A Mars rock
- (B) A video game
- (C) A new picture of Mars
- (D) A letter

2. What are yardangs?

- (A) Rivers
- (B) Cliffs shaped by wind
- (C) Moons
- (D) Clouds

3. How many photos were put together?

- (A) Ninety
- (B) Six
- (C) Twenty
- (D) One

4. What did Mars have long ago, according to the rock layers?

- (A) Cities
- (B) Lakes and streams
- (C) Penguins
- (D) Forests

5. What might the strange layer be made of?

- (A) Ash from ancient volcanoes
- (B) Plastic
- (C) Snow
- (D) Chocolate

6. When should Curiosity reach the cliffs?

- (A) Tomorrow
- (B) In 2027
- (C) In 1990
- (D) Never

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Ashwin Vasavada: Says the strange layer might be ash from ancient volcanoes.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):